Emma Johnston



Born in 1973, Australian marine biologist Emma Johnston earned her Ph.D. in marine biology in 2002. In 2017, she became Dean of Science at the University of New South Wales (UNSW), and Head of its Applied Marine and Estuarine Ecology Lab, which studies human impacts on marine ecosystems. In 2025, she became Vice Chancellor of the University of Melbourne.

A leading authority in marine science and conservation, Johnston discovered how nonnative species can invade waterways in coastal areas by adhering to rafts of plastic pollution floating on the oceans. She has also studied marine communities in the Antarctic, developed new biomonitoring techniques, and advised agencies on the management of estuarine biodiversity.

Key works

2009 "Contaminants reduce the richness and evenness of marine communities," *Environmental Pollution*

2017 "Building 'blue': an eco-engineering framework for foreshore developments," *Journal of Environmental Management*

See also: Pesticides • Acid rain • Light pollution • A plastic wasteland • The water crisis • Waste disposal